

Heroes & Villains 2009

Heroes

Aradhana Prakash TRUE GRIT

As a young girl, she witnessed her best friend being molested by a senior police officer. Nineteen years later, as a mother of two, she was appalled to find the molester getting away with just a six-month prison term and a fine of Rs 1,000. For Aradhana Prakash, who took a flight from Australia to testify against former Haryana DGP SPS Rathore, it was justice denied to her friend Ruchika who had committed suicide in the face of the harassment her family had to endure at the hands of Rathore. Undeterred, Aradhana continued her fight for justice and now has reasons to smile as the case has been reopened and fresh FIRs filed against Rathore.

KESHAV SINGH



Justice K. Kannan BARE FACTS

He triggered a nationwide debate when he became the first judge to declare his assets in public. But Justice K. Kannan fails to understand the hullabaloo around his 'honesty' as he says a dishonest judge is a contradiction. The 55-year-old Punjab and Haryana High Court judge, however, believes that judges cannot be treated as politicians. "I do not agree in principle with demands to keep the wealth details of judges in the public domain, yet I want to prove a point that we have nothing to hide," Kannan writes in his blog.



Venkatraman Ramakrishnan NOBLE NUGGETS

For him fame is a "distraction". And he makes politically incorrect statements. "I honestly don't think my roots in India have much to do with it," said Venkatraman Ramakrishnan after winning the Nobel Prize for Chemistry for his pioneering work on ribosomes. Born in 1952 at Chidambaram in Tamil Nadu, he earned his BSc. in Physics from M. S. University in Baroda, Gujarat. He left the country to pursue higher studies in the US where he later got settled and attained citizenship. When asked how students could emulate him and "win a Nobel for India", he said, "That is the wrong question to ask. You can't go into science thinking of a Nobel Prize. You can only go into science because you are interested in it."



SISTERS IN ARMS

They lost their husbands in the 26/11 terrorist attacks in Mumbai, but refused to just sit back and grieve over the loss. Instead, they asked uncomfortable questions and the Mumbai Police were at a loss. It was the stoic resilience of Kavita Karkare, wife of slain anti-terrorist squad chief Hemant Karkare, that forced the Mumbai Police to come up with absurd theories about her husband's death. Vinita Kamte, wife of assistant commissioner of police Ashok Kamte, who was killed along with Karkare, went a step ahead and invoked the RTI Act. The result was a book, *To the Last Bullet*, which pierced through the inefficiencies of the police force.

BHASKAR PALLI/ANAND BODHANATH/REUTERS

